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Enhancing Reading Proficiency Among Grade 2 Struggling Readers Through Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) in Albay Central School

INTRODUCTION

Reading is the most fundamental skill a child acquires in school, and arguably the most consequential. It is through reading that a child gains access to the wider world of knowledge, learns to think critically, communicates ideas, and participates fully in the life of the community. Because nearly all school learning is mediated by printed text, reading is not merely one subject among many; it is the gateway through which every other subject is learned. For this reason, the international community, through Sustainable Development Goal 4, has committed to ensuring that all children complete primary education with relevant and effective learning outcomes (United Nations, 2015), beginning with the most basic outcome of all: the ability to read with understanding. The early grades of elementary school are where this commitment is either fulfilled or broken.

Reading, however, does not develop naturally in the way that spoken language does; it must be deliberately taught. Chall (1983) described reading development as a progression of stages in which children in the primary grades are "learning to read," mastering the alphabetic code and building fluency, before they transition at around Grade 4 to "reading to learn," when reading becomes the primary tool for acquiring new knowledge. Ehri (2005) explained that children become skilled word readers by forming connections between letters and sounds, moving from the pre-alphabetic and partial-alphabetic phases to the full and consolidated alphabetic phases, until words are recognized instantly by sight. Once word recognition becomes automatic, the reader's limited attention is freed for understanding meaning (LaBerge & Samuels, 1974). The Simple View of Reading (Gough & Tunmer, 1986) captures this relationship by proposing

that reading comprehension is the product of decoding and language comprehension: if either component is weak, comprehension fails. Scarborough (2001), in her widely used "reading rope" model, likewise illustrates that skilled reading is woven from two major strands, namely, word recognition (phonological awareness, decoding, and sight recognition) and language comprehension (background knowledge, vocabulary, language structures, verbal reasoning, and literacy knowledge), which become increasingly automatic and strategic over time. Taken together, these frameworks make it clear that Grade 2 is a decisive year: it is the stage at which the foundations of word recognition must be secured if a child is to read for meaning in the grades that follow.

When these foundations are not secured, the consequences are serious and long-lasting. Juel (1988), in a longitudinal study that followed 54 children from Grade 1 to Grade 4, found that a child who was a poor reader at the end of Grade 1 had an 88 percent probability of remaining a poor reader at the end of Grade 4. Stanovich (1986) described this widening gap as the "Matthew effect" in reading: children who read well read more, acquire more vocabulary and knowledge, and become even better readers, while children who struggle read less, learn less, and fall further and further behind. The effects extend well beyond the elementary years. Hernandez (2011) reported that children who were not reading proficiently by the end of Grade 3 were four times more likely not to graduate from high school on time than their proficient peers. Torgesen (2004) thus described early reading failure as a "devastating downward spiral" and argued that the most effective way to prevent it is to intervene early, intensively, and systematically. Snow, Burns, and Griffin (1998) similarly concluded that most reading difficulties can be prevented when children at risk are identified early and provided with high-quality instruction suited to their needs.

Unfortunately, millions of children around the world are not acquiring these foundational skills. The UNESCO Institute for Statistics (2017) reported that more than 617 million children and adolescents worldwide were not achieving minimum proficiency levels in reading and mathematics, many of them despite being in school. The World Bank (2022) further estimated that, in the aftermath of the COVID-19 pandemic, as many as 70 percent of 10-year-old children in low- and middle-income countries may be unable to read and understand a simple, age-appropriate text, a condition it describes as "learning poverty." Prolonged school closures disrupted instruction at the very stage when young children most needed direct and sustained guidance in learning to read, and the effects of this disruption continue to be felt in classrooms today.

The Philippines stands among the countries most severely affected by this learning crisis. In the 2018 Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA), Filipino 15-

year-old learners obtained a mean reading score of 340, the lowest among the 79 participating countries and economies and far below the OECD average of 487 (OECD, 2019). In PISA 2022, the country's mean reading score of 347 remained among the lowest of all participants, against an OECD average of 476 (OECD, 2023). These results are not a problem of secondary education alone; they reflect gaps that begin in the earliest grades. The 2019 Southeast Asia Primary Learning Metrics (SEA-PLM) revealed that only 10 percent of Filipino Grade 5 learners reached the minimum reading proficiency expected at the end of primary school (UNICEF & SEAMEO, 2020). The World Bank (2022) likewise placed the learning poverty rate of the Philippines at about 91 percent, which means that roughly nine out of ten Filipino children at age 10 cannot read and understand a simple text appropriate for their age. The Second Congressional Commission on Education (EDCOM 2, 2024), in its Year One report, underscored the urgency of strengthening foundational literacy in the early grades as a cornerstone of reforming Philippine basic education. To an elementary school teacher, these figures are more than statistics; they describe the children who sit in our classrooms every day.

The Philippine government has responded to this challenge through a series of laws, policies, and programs. The 1987 Philippine Constitution, Article XIV, Section 1, mandates the State to protect and promote the right of all citizens to quality education at all levels. Republic Act No. 10533, or the Enhanced Basic Education Act of 2013, requires a curriculum that is learner-centered, developmentally appropriate, and contextualized, and that builds strong foundational skills in the early grades. The Department of Education (DepEd) has long implemented the Every Child a Reader Program (ECARP), which aims to make every Filipino child a reader and writer at his or her grade level, and strengthened early-grade teaching through the Early Language, Literacy, and Numeracy (ELLN) Program (DepEd Order No. 12, s. 2015). The Philippine Informal Reading Inventory (Phil-IRI) was revised through DepEd Order No. 14, s. 2018 as a classroom-based tool for determining learners' reading levels and guiding teachers in planning interventions, while the "Hamon: Bawat Bata Bumabasa" (3Bs) initiative (DepEd Memorandum No. 173, s. 2019) called on all schools to intensify their reading advocacy and intervention efforts. More recently, the National Learning Recovery Program (DepEd Order No. 13, s. 2023), the implementation of Catch-Up Fridays (DepEd Memorandum No. 001, s. 2024), and the MATATAG Curriculum (DepEd Order No. 10, s. 2024) have placed foundational literacy at the center of the Department's reform agenda. In 2024, Republic Act No. 12028, or the Academic Recovery and Accessible Learning (ARAL) Program Act, was enacted to

provide a national learning intervention program, including tutorial sessions in reading, for learners who have not attained the expected level of proficiency.

Yet policies, however well crafted, succeed or fail at the level of the classroom. A program becomes real only when a teacher sits down with a child who cannot yet read and has the right material, the right strategy, and enough time to help that child. Research offers clear guidance on what this help should look like. The National Reading Panel (2000) identified five essential components of effective reading instruction, namely, phonemic awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary, and comprehension, and found that these are best taught explicitly and systematically. In a best-evidence synthesis of programs for struggling readers, Slavin, Lake, Davis, and Madden (2011) found that one-to-one and small-group tutoring, particularly approaches with a strong emphasis on phonics, produced substantial positive effects on reading achievement. Wanzek and Vaughn (2007) likewise reported that extensive early reading interventions delivered in small groups yielded meaningful gains for struggling learners, especially when begun in the primary grades. The Response to Intervention (RTI) framework (Fuchs & Fuchs, 2006) translates these findings into practice through tiered support, in which learners who do not respond adequately to regular classroom instruction receive more targeted and intensive intervention while their progress is closely monitored.

Central to every effective intervention are the materials that teachers use. Struggling readers need texts and activities that match their current level of skill, that provide repeated and structured practice, and that gradually increase in difficulty. Vygotsky's (1978) concept of the Zone of Proximal Development explains that learning is most productive when tasks lie just beyond what a learner can accomplish independently but within what the learner can achieve with guidance. Wood, Bruner, and Ross (1976) described this guidance as scaffolding, a temporary support that is gradually withdrawn as the learner gains competence. Well-designed intervention materials serve as a tangible form of scaffolding: decodable words and sentences allow a child to apply newly learned letter-sound patterns with success, leveled passages build fluency and confidence, and guided comprehension questions model how good readers think about a text. Tomlinson (2011) emphasizes that effective learning materials should be relevant to the learners, engaging, and responsive to their needs and context, qualities that generic, one-size-fits-all materials often lack.

In the reality of many Philippine public schools, however, such materials remain scarce. Teachers frequently contend with a shortage of supplementary reading materials that are leveled, decodable, and suited to learners who are reading below grade level.

Commercially produced materials are often costly, not aligned with the learning competencies of the curriculum, or distant from the language and everyday experiences of the learners. In the Province of Albay, where most children speak Bikol at home, young learners must also find their way in reading Filipino and English, languages that some of them encounter mainly in school. Republic Act No. 10533 recognizes such realities by requiring that the curriculum be contextualized and by allowing schools to localize and enhance it based on their respective educational and social contexts. DepEd, through the Learning Action Cell (LAC) mechanism established in DepEd Order No. 35, s. 2016, has likewise encouraged teachers to work collaboratively in developing and contextualizing learning resources. It is within this policy space that teacher-developed Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) find both their justification and their promise.

At Albay Central School, these national and regional realities take on familiar faces. As an elementary school teacher, the researcher has witnessed, year after year, the quiet struggle of Grade 2 learners who have not yet learned to read. Some can recite the alphabet song flawlessly but cannot tell the sound that a letter makes. Others confuse letters with similar shapes, such as b and d or p and q, or read word by word in a slow and halting manner, losing the meaning of a sentence before reaching its end. Many rely on pictures or on guessing rather than on decoding, and a number of those who can sound out words are unable to answer even simple questions about what they have just read. Just as telling are the behaviors that accompany these difficulties: learners who avoid reading aloud, who look away when called upon, or who quietly wait for a seatmate to answer. Over time, repeated failure erodes their confidence and motivation, and the reading gap begins to widen into a learning gap across all subjects.

The beginning-of-the-year reading assessments administered in the school have confirmed what daily classroom observation suggests: a number of Grade 2 learners are reading below the level expected for their grade. The researcher has noted several factors that appear to contribute to this situation, including limited exposure to print before entering school, scarce reading materials at home, varying levels of parental support, irregular attendance, and large class sizes that make individualized instruction difficult. Although the school has implemented reading programs in line with DepEd initiatives, the materials at hand are not always suited to the specific needs of learners who are still at the beginning stages of reading. Struggling readers need more than additional time; they need materials designed precisely for the skills they have yet to master.

It is in response to these needs that the researcher proposes the use of Reading Intervention Materials (RIM). In this study, RIM refers to a set of teacher-developed and

contextualized reading materials designed to address the specific reading difficulties of Grade 2 struggling readers. Anchored on the five components of reading identified by the National Reading Panel (2000), the materials progress systematically from letter-sound knowledge to word recognition, from phrase and sentence reading to the fluent reading of short connected texts, and from literal to higher-level comprehension. They include letter-sound cards and phonics drills, decodable word lists and word-building activities, high-frequency sight word cards, phrase and sentence strips, leveled reading passages and short stories drawn from familiar local settings, and comprehension activities that guide learners in recalling details, sequencing events, and making simple inferences about what they have read. The materials will be used in explicit, systematic, and structured small-group and one-on-one sessions, with the learners' progress monitored regularly to guide instruction.

While numerous studies have established the general effectiveness of early reading interventions, there remains limited documented evidence on the effectiveness of teacher-developed and contextualized reading intervention materials for Grade 2 struggling readers in the specific setting of Albay Central School. Evidence generated from within the school, by a teacher who knows its learners, is especially valuable because it can directly inform the decisions of teachers, school heads, and the Learning Action Cell on which materials and practices to adopt, refine, or expand. This study seeks to provide such evidence.

Guided by these considerations, this study aims to determine the extent to which the use of Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) enhances the reading proficiency of Grade 2 struggling readers at Albay Central School. It examines the learners' reading proficiency before and after the intervention, evaluates the acceptability of the materials, and identifies the challenges encountered in their use, with the end goal of proposing an action plan for sustained reading improvement. At its heart, this study is driven by a conviction that every elementary school teacher holds to be true: no child is too far behind to learn to read, and with the right support at the right time, every struggling reader can become a confident and independent reader. To teach a child to read is to open every other door of learning, and this study is the researcher's humble contribution to opening those doors for the Grade 2 learners of Albay Central School.

OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

This study aims to enhance the reading proficiency of Grade 2 struggling readers through the use of Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) at Albay Central School during the School Year 2026–2027.

Specifically, it aims to:

1. Determine the reading proficiency level of the Grade 2 struggling readers before the use of the RIM (pre-test) in terms of:
    a. letter-sound knowledge;
    b. word recognition;
    c. reading fluency; and
    d. reading comprehension.
2. Describe the Reading Intervention Materials (RIM) developed and utilized in the study in terms of their content, activities, and mode of delivery.
3. Determine the reading proficiency level of the Grade 2 struggling readers after the use of the RIM (post-test) in terms of:
    a. letter-sound knowledge;
    b. word recognition;
    c. reading fluency; and
    d. reading comprehension.
4. Ascertain whether there is a significant difference between the pre-test and post-test reading proficiency levels of the Grade 2 struggling readers.
5. Determine the level of acceptability of the RIM as evaluated by teachers and reading experts in terms of:
    a. content;
    b. format and design;
    c. language and readability; and
    d. usefulness.
6. Identify the challenges encountered by the teacher and the learners in the utilization of the RIM.
7. Propose a reading enhancement action plan based on the findings of the study.

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